The Waterfront Brief

Weekly sustainment intelligence for naval shipyard leadership · For middle and senior shipyard management

Vol. 1, No. 3 — Week 31 **July 31, 2026**

Two things happened this week worth filing. The submarine industrial base finally got its money, $76.6 billion of it, after a negotiation that ran nearly three years, and roughly $5 billion of that is aimed at the workforce rather than the boats. Meanwhile advanced manufacturing quietly crossed a line it had not crossed before: at RIMPAC, Marines printed parts at sea, an unmanned boat carried them to a Navy ship, and soldiers built drones out of the same delivery. The rest of the week ran to organic repair capability, cold spray standing up at Crane and an obsolete boiler part getting printed in Philadelphia, plus small Louisiana workboat yards picking up unmanned-vessel work. Scope: US shipbuilding, US Navy sustainment, and INDOPACOM partners. Labels: FACT is attributed to the named source in the same sentence; Assessment is this desk's read; Speculation is flagged.

WATERFRONT OPS & PRODUCTION

The unmanned-vessel work is going to crewboat yards

FACT: The Maritime Executive reported on July 6, 2026 that Huntington Ingalls Industries has agreed to work with Halimar Shipyard of Morgan City, Louisiana, to expand production of its Romulus 151 unmanned surface vessel, making Halimar the second Louisiana workboat yard on the program after Breaux Brothers Enterprises outside New Iberia. FACT: the same report describes Romulus as a fast, midsize vessel built to the Navy's Medium Unmanned Surface Vessel (MUSV) requirements, a containerized-payload carrier with capacity for two forty-foot equivalent units and a range of 2,500 nautical miles, and one of seven competing designs approved into the MUSV prototype evaluation phase. FACT: the report quotes HII executive vice president Andy Green, earlier this year, saying Romulus is “engineered from the outset for scale” by aligning design, autonomy and manufacturing into a production model.

Assessment: the interesting part is not the boat, it is the address. Both partner yards are commercially focused aluminum builders that made their names on crewboats and fast supply vessels for the offshore oil industry, not on Navy programs. If unmanned surface vessels get built at that tier, the competition for aluminum welders and outfitters shifts to a labor pool that public yards and the big primes have not historically had to fight over.

> **Bottom line:** Watch which yards get the second and third USV awards, because that is where your next welder shortage comes from.

Sources: The Maritime Executive, Jul 6, 2026

MAINTENANCE ENGINEERING & TECHNOLOGIES

Printed at sea, delivered by an unmanned boat, assembled ashore

FACT: the Navy reported on July 21, 2026 that the Naval Postgraduate School's Consortium for Advanced Manufacturing Research and Education (CAMRE) and FLEETWERX demonstrated a logistics chain during RIMPAC 2026 in which Marines manufactured replacement parts aboard ship using expeditionary advanced manufacturing equipment, a digitally crewed surface vessel (DCSV) carried those components to a US Navy ship, and the delivery completed what the release calls the Department of the Navy's first digitally crewed resupply. FACT: the same release states the DCSV then carried drone components to the 25th Infantry Division's Lightning Lab, where Marines and Soldiers assembled the systems and deployed them for testing at Makua Range. FACT: the Navy credits the workflow to the Joint Advanced Manufacturing System (JAMS), a digital command and control platform developed through CAMRE with the Marine Innovation Unit, which tracks manufacturing requests and assigns production across distributed nodes.

FACT: in a separate release dated July 7, 2026, the Navy said CAMRE was preparing what organizers describe as the largest advanced manufacturing demonstration ever conducted by the Department of War, and that RIMPAC 2026 involves 35 nations, roughly 40 surface ships, five submarines, more than 140 aircraft and 25,000 personnel.

Assessment: hold those two releases apart, because the difference between them is the whole story. The July 7 release is a plan and carries a superlative the Navy attributes to organizers rather than asserting itself. The July 21 release is a completed event with a named delivery. Expeditionary manufacturing has been promised for a decade; this is the first time this desk has seen the Navy describe the full chain, request to part to hull to assembled system, as having actually run.

> **Bottom line:** The question for your yard is no longer whether a part can be printed forward, it is which of your repair packages could be re-planned around a part arriving in hours instead of weeks, and who holds the technical data package when it is.

Sources: Navy.mil, Jul 21, 2026; Navy.mil, Jul 7, 2026

Organic repair capability, at both ends of the glamour scale

FACT: NAVSEA reported on July 16, 2026 that Naval Surface Warfare Center, Crane Division opened its Metal Additive Manufacturing (MADMAN) Repair Center, using low-pressure and high-pressure cold spray to extend the life of naval components. FACT: NSWC Crane Commanding Officer Capt. Rex Boonyobhas is quoted saying the center "allows us to shift our focus from 'replace' to 'repair'" and calling it "the first organic industrial base facility for non-structural cold spray within the Navy." FACT: the release explains that cold spray is a solid-state process that uses compressed gas to project metal powder at high speed, and that because it does not rely on thermal melting it avoids the cracking and loss of strength that traditional fusion welding can introduce. FACT: it states the low-pressure systems are agile and portable, so repair capability can be projected out to where the component is.

At the other end of the scale from a new facility, the same capability shows up as one discontinued part on a legacy steam plant.

FACT: NAVSEA's Philadelphia division reported on June 11, 2026 that its engineers are using additive manufacturing to redesign and produce the wallbox for the Boiler Combustion Monitoring System, because the existing part is obsolete and no longer available through traditional supply channels. FACT: the release states the system is installed on the Navy's six Wasp-class amphibious assault ships and on USS Blue Ridge (LCC 19), the Seventh Fleet flagship. FACT: the NAVSEA release describes the safety function plainly: the wallbox gives the furnace camera and inspection light a protected path into the boiler furnace, and boiler operators use that view to check the furnace deck for unburned fuel before lighting the burners, because if a burner flame goes out, fuel oil can build on the hot furnace floor, vaporize, and create a potentially explosive situation. FACT: Steam Systems in-service engineering agent Ramazan Meta is quoted saying additive manufacturing let the team test design changes while solving the supply problem.

Assessment: "organic" is the word that matters in both stories. Crane is repair capability inside the naval enterprise rather than at a vendor, on parts that fusion welding would have risked condemning, and the portable low-pressure systems suggest the intent is eventually to bring the process to the pier rather than ship components to Indiana.

Philadelphia is the same idea at the other end: no demonstration, no superlative, just a discontinued part printed because nobody sells it any more, with a design improvement folded in on the way. The second kind is what most of your additive work will actually look like.

> **Bottom line:** Two calls come out of this. If you own corroded non-structural components you currently scrap or send out, ask NSWC Crane about their intake process before you write next year's material budget. And treat your obsolescence list as an additive candidate list, because the wallbox shows that path runs through the in-service engineering agent, not the print shop.

Sources: NAVSEA, Jul 16, 2026; NAVSEA, Jun 11, 2026

OPERATIONS MAINTENANCE & READINESS

Korea's repair bench, and what it has actually absorbed

FACT: The Maritime Executive reported on January 7, 2026 that HD Hyundai Heavy Industries won a maintenance, repair and overhaul contract for USNS Cesar Chavez, a 41,000-ton Lewis and Clark-class dry cargo ship then assigned to the US Seventh Fleet, with work scheduled to begin January 19 at Ulsan, redelivery anticipated in March, and roughly 100 maintenance items in scope. FACT: the same report states its sister ship USNS Alan Shepard had been at the yard since late September under an initial contract of about 60 maintenance tasks, that Korea broke into the US Navy MRO segment in 2024, and that earlier reports valued the US MRO business at more than $14.5 billion. FACT: Naval News reported on January 14, 2026 that the first of six offshore patrol vessels HD Hyundai is building for the Philippines, the future BRP Rajah Sulayman (PS-20), departed Ulsan on January 13, part of a ₱30 billion (about $573 million) contract signed in 2022 for 2,400-ton, 94-meter ships.

Assessment: both anchors here are from January, so read this as the standing thread rather than this week's news. The thread is worth tracking anyway, because the same Korean yards absorbing US auxiliary MRO are simultaneously delivering new construction to a third partner navy, and capacity claimed by one is not available to the other.

> **Bottom line:** Forward MRO is real and growing, but the constraint is a yard's total berth and labor, so watch Korean new-construction backlogs as a leading indicator of MRO slot availability.

Sources: The Maritime Executive, Jan 7, 2026; Naval News, Jan 14, 2026

BUSINESS PRACTICES & STRATEGY

$76.6 billion, and the $5 billion inside it that is about people

FACT: USNI News reported on July 29, 2026 that the Navy awarded General Dynamics Electric Boat and HII $76.6 billion for the next batch of attack and ballistic missile submarines, after a delay of nearly three years. FACT: USNI reports the award splits into $42.1 billion for nine Block VI Virginia-class attack boats plus material for a tenth, $29.5 billion for five Build II Columbia-class ballistic missile submarines, and $5 billion for workforce improvements between Electric Boat and HII. FACT: the July 29 Pentagon contract announcement, quoted by USNI, states the Block VI award includes previously announced material awards, including long-lead-time and economic ordering quantity material, and previously awarded investments in shipbuilder productivity efforts. FACT: USNI reports the delay traces to 2022, when negotiations over the last two Block V boats stalled for 18 months over a missile indemnification issue, after which the Navy and the builders struggled for years over workforce wages that rose during the pandemic inflation spike, and that in April 2025 the service awarded $18.5 billion covering future attack boats Baltimore (SSN-812) and Atlanta (SSN-813) plus additional workforce wage support. FACT:

Electric Boat president Mark Rayha is quoted saying the modifications give the company and its suppliers “the demand certainty we need to continue investing in capacity and hiring the workforce necessary to ensure we deliver these important national security assets on schedule.”

Assessment: the headline number is a procurement story, but the $5 billion workforce line and the wage dispute that held the deal up for years are the sustainment story. A submarine program that could not close a contract because of what it costs to keep trained people is describing the same labor market every public yard is hiring into.

> **Bottom line:** Demand certainty at the primes pulls on the same regional trades pool you recruit from; expect the hiring pressure near Groton and Newport News to tighten, and plan your own pipeline against that, not against your own attrition rate alone.

Sources: USNI News, Jul 29, 2026

Standing thread: where the Landing Ship Medium is actually getting built

FACT: USNI News reported on February 18, 2026 that the Navy named Bollinger Shipyards and Fincantieri Marinette Marine as the two yards for initial Landing Ship Medium production, and quoted a Navy release stating that Bollinger was awarded a contract in September 2025 for LSM long-lead-time procurement and lead-ship engineering design, that Fincantieri will execute work to build four ships, and that the vessel construction manager will then decide the best strategy for follow-on hulls. FACT: the same report states the McClung-class LSM is based on Dutch shipbuilder Damen’s LST-100, an in-service design the Navy turned to after retooling the program late in 2025, and quotes program executive officer for ships Rear Adm. Brian Metcalf describing the approach as a “mature, ‘build-to-print’ design” with a VCM managing production to streamline oversight. FACT: USNI reports the Fiscal Year 2026 National Defense Authorization Act permits the Navy to use a vessel construction manager for the first eight LSMs as well as future light replenishment oilers and other auxiliaries, and notes the Maritime Administration used the same model to build five National Security Multi-Mission Vessels at what is now Hanwha Philly Shipyard.

Assessment: this anchor is from February, so it runs here as the standing thread behind issue No. 1’s VCM coverage rather than as news. It matters now because the VCM model is spreading from one program to a class of auxiliaries, and because Marinette is absorbing LSM work into the hole left by the cancelled Constellation frigates, which is a capacity shift worth tracking.

> **Bottom line:** If your yard bids auxiliary or amphibious work, the vessel construction manager is becoming the party you negotiate with rather than the program office, and build-to-print foreign designs change what “engineering support” means in your proposal.

Sources: USNI News, Feb 18, 2026

The Waterfront Brief is compiled weekly by the B2 vault's research engine from NAVSEA releases, USNI News, Naval News, GAO and congressional records, defense.gov, RAND, Defense News, Breaking Defense, The Maritime Executive, NSRP, ASNE, SNAME, arXiv, and academic publishers (16 sources staged this week; 13 quarantined as stale, 5 of them after this desk verified dates the fetcher could not read), then synthesized and labeled by hand. Scope: US shipbuilding, US Navy sustainment, and INDOPACOM partners; out-of-area items only for a direct, stated lesson. Freshness policy: every article's anchor source is under 12 months old; anything older appears only as dated context or a flagged exception. FACT means the named source says it, not that this desk has independently verified it. Corrections welcome; the staged sources are retained for audit.

UPCOMING EVENTS

Generated from the events registry (dates and registration deadlines exactly as organizers publish them; 12-month window, print edition trims the furthest-out rows to one page).

Dates	Event	Register by	Why it matters
Aug 18-19, 2026	NSRP Electrical Technologies Panel Meeting, Pullman, WA (also virtual)	None published (Cvent link open)	The panel behind the fiber-optic switchboard-sensing pilot; electrical condition-monitoring tech transfer
Aug 24-25, 2026	NSRP Workforce & Compliance Panel Meeting, Pensacola, FL	In-person closes Aug 13, 2026	Cross-yard workforce practices against the Navy's 250,000-hire target
Sep 22-24, 2026	Fleet Maintenance & Modernization Symposium (FMMS) 2026, Virginia Beach, VA (ASNE)	Early bird thru Aug 16, 2026	The flagship fleet-maintenance event for exactly this readership
Sep 29 - Oct 2, 2026	SCA Fall Membership Meeting 2026, Washington, DC	Members only; none published	The surface-repair industrial base's Hill-and-Navy engagement window
Oct 28-29, 2026	Arctic Operations Symposium 2026, Baltimore, MD (ASNE)	Not published yet	Cold-region sustainment, hull and machinery readiness
Nov 16-17, 2026	Navy Procurement Outlook Summit, Reston, VA (Defense Leadership Forum)	Eventbrite open; no deadline published	Shipbuilding-plan and VCM-era procurement priorities, with contracting-officer access; billed as the 2027 outlook
Dec 7-9, 2026	TSS/CSS Symposium, Arlington, VA (ASNE)	Not published yet	Technology, systems and ships exchange near the NAVSEA customer
Jan 26-28, 2027	Military Additive Manufacturing Summit (MILAM), Tampa, FL	Tiers: Jul 31 / Oct 2 / Dec 4; closes Jan 22	Metal and polymer print qualification and NAVSEA-spec adoption; the AM-pipeline event
Mar 23-25, 2027	NSRP All Panel Meeting 2027	"Coming soon" per NSRP	Where yard R&D ideas get socialized and teamed program-wide

Beyond the 12-month window and rolling in as it approaches: Indo Pacific 2027 International Maritime Exposition (Nov 2-4, 2027). Two AM-lane events are on the registry without published dates and will print when the organizers set them: the annual ATDM and AM CoE Summit in Danville, and the next Defense Manufacturing Conference.